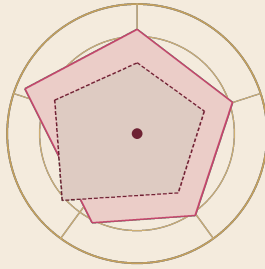


A FREE GUIDE

The 10 Conversations to Have Before You Get Married

The ones that matter more than the napkins.



From the makers of **The Marriage Operating Manual** — the guided date-night workbook for couples planning the marriage, not just the wedding.

READ THIS FIRST

Read this first

You've planned the wedding down to the napkins. This is for the part that comes after the napkins.

The average couple spends 200+ hours planning their wedding day, and almost none deliberately planning the marriage. Not because they don't care — because nobody hands them a way to do it that isn't a counselling course or an awkward "we need to talk."

Here's the way. Ten conversations, each with three starter questions. You don't need to do them all tonight. You don't need candles (though we're not against candles). You just need to actually have them — ideally *before* the registrar asks if anyone objects.

One rule for all ten: honesty beats harmony. A difference you discover now is a win. A difference that ambushes you in year three is a fight.

THE 10 CONVERSATIONS

CONVERSATION 1

What are we actually building?

Everyone knows what wedding they want. Fewer couples can describe the marriage they want. Get the big picture down first — everything else hangs off it.

- ◆ Which couple do you look at and think “I’d take that”? What have they got?
- ◆ Fifty years from now at your anniversary dinner — where is it, and what’s the toast to?
- ◆ What’s one thing from the home you grew up in that you want to repeat — and one you’re determined not to?

CONVERSATION 2

How we talk — especially when it’s gone a bit wrong

Every couple has a communication pattern. Most never say it out loud. Saying it out loud is the whole trick.

- ◆ When something’s bothering you, how long does it usually take you to say so? (Minutes? Days? A strategic sigh?)
- ◆ How does each of you know when the other one is *not fine*, whatever they’re claiming?
- ◆ What’s one thing your partner does mid-disagreement that actually helps?

THE 10 CONVERSATIONS

CONVERSATION 3

The money conversation — all of it

Money is the most-cited source of marital conflict and the least-had conversation before the wedding. Everything on the table, including that credit card.

- ◆ What did money feel like in the house you grew up in — tight, easy, secret, loud?
- ◆ Joint account, separate accounts, or the fashionable hybrid? Why?
- ◆ What's a purchase either of you could make without checking in first? Name the number. Watch each other's faces.

CONVERSATION 4

Kids — or not. The whole conversation

Not just the headline yes/no. The timing, the number, the “what if we can't”, the “what if we disagree later”, and who's doing the 3am shift.

- ◆ Where is each of you, honestly, on a scale from “definitely” to “definitely not” — and how long has that been your answer?
- ◆ If kids happen: what changes about work, money, and whose career flexes?
- ◆ If kids don't happen — by choice or not — what does a full life look like for you two?

THE 10 CONVERSATIONS

CONVERSATION 5

How we fight

You will fight. Married couples who do well aren't the ones who never fight — they're the ones who repair fast. Agree the rules of engagement in peacetime.

- ◆ What's your conflict style — pursue it, flee it, go quiet, go loud?
- ◆ What's genuinely off-limits in a fight? (Exes, family, “you always”, the thing told in confidence?)
- ◆ After a fight: what's the move that tells you it's over? Who usually makes it?

CONVERSATION 6

Who does what

The bin bags conversation — and the fairness conversation underneath it. Resentment about domestic load is slow, quiet, and entirely preventable.

- ◆ Right now, who *notices* what needs doing? (Noticing is the job. Doing it is the second job.)
- ◆ Which jobs do you each actively hate, and which do you weirdly not mind?
- ◆ If one of you earns more, does that change who does what at home? Careful. Take your time.

THE 10 CONVERSATIONS

CONVERSATION 7

Closeness

The couples who stay couples keep being a couple — not just co-managers of a household with a shared calendar and a mortgage.

- ◆ What makes you feel most loved — words, time, touch, help, gifts? (Guess your partner's answer first. Then check.)
- ◆ What's your early-warning sign that you two are drifting into "flatmates who kiss goodnight"?
- ◆ What's one thing from your early dating days you'd smuggle back in?

CONVERSATION 8

Us against the rain

In-laws, emergencies, redundancy, illness, grief. You can't plan the storm. You can decide, now, that it's you two against the rain — and what a united front actually looks like.

- ◆ When your family and your partner disagree — publicly — whose side are you visibly on?
- ◆ If one of you lost your job next month, what's the plan for the first week?
- ◆ Who is allowed to know about your arguments? (Your mum? Their mate? The group chat? Nobody?)

THE 10 CONVERSATIONS

CONVERSATION 9

The wedding itself

One conversation about the wedding — but not about napkins. About what the day is for, before it eats eighteen months of your life.

- ◆ What are the three moments of the day that actually matter to each of you?
- ◆ What's each of you quietly dreading — and can any of it just be... deleted?
- ◆ Whose approval are you still planning parts of this day for? Was that on purpose?

CONVERSATION 10

How we'll change

You're not marrying the person in front of you. You're marrying every version of them for the next fifty years. Sight unseen. (So are they. Bit of nerve, really.)

- ◆ What do you hope is different about you at 40? At 60?
- ◆ What would you want to do if the other one changed in a way you didn't expect — new career, new beliefs, new priorities?
- ◆ When will you two check in on the marriage itself — properly, not in passing? Anniversary audit? Annual away-day?

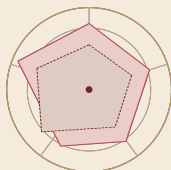
WHAT TO DO WITH ALL THIS

What to do with all this

If you had these conversations and mostly nodded along: excellent. Put a date in the calendar to have them again in a year — the answers move.

If you found differences: even better. Every one of them is now something you *know about*, which puts you ahead of most couples walking down most aisles.

And if you want the full version — the guided date nights, the reveal ritual, the written agreements, the Marriage Operating Manual you build together and sign like the management you now are — that's **The Marriage Operating Manual**.



Ten conversations. One marriage, planned.

Launching this autumn — you're already on the list.

@themarriageoperatingmanual